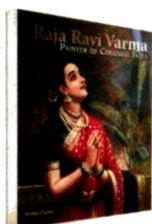


A Brush with HISTORY

India's first painter of iconic images gets a study of his life and art he deserves



**RAJA RAVI
VARMA: PAINTER
OF COLONIAL
INDIA**

by RUPKA CHAWLA
Mapin

Price: Rs 3,950

Pages: 360

By S. Kalidas

If there was ever a painter who could claim to have completely changed the way popular Indian imagination pictured its gods, goddesses, myths and legends, then it was that charismatic Keralite who went by the enigmatic name of Raja Ravi Varma (1848-1906). Till Ravi Varma arrived on the scene, Indian art was wondrous, metaphoric, symbolic, abstract, geometric and much more but never directly representational of the retinal reality. Most importantly, Hindu gods were not perceived to be made in the image of man. They were variously and colloquially imaged by the depiction of their attributes—so Shiva, for example, was represented by the phallic Lingam—in hundreds of different styles and manners. But the setting up of the Ravi Varma Press in 1894 in Bombay changed all that. Soon, from Simla to Trivandrum and from Calcutta to Bombay, every middle-class Hindu home in the 20th century (and largely even today) was (and is) decorated with highly affordable prints of Ravi Varma's "natural and realistic" renderings of Lakshmi, Saraswati, Rama,

(CLOCKWISE FROM RIGHT) RAVI VARMA'S
DRAUPADI CARRYING LIQUOR JAR;
LADY WITH A FRUIT AND; SARASWATI

